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TO: Medford City Council
FROM: Councilor Justin Tseng
DATE: May 20, 2026
RE: Recommendations for the City Council from the Urban Forest Management Plan

Overview

The Urban Forest Management Plan (UFMP) calls for Medford to move from a largely reactive forestry model toward a more proactive one, with higher annual planting, stronger young-tree care, better use of inventory and canopy data, and closer integration of trees into capital planning. The plan is explicit that implementation will depend on available funding, staffing, and City priorities. (pp. 2, 12, 69, 73, 76, 82)

The clearest budget signal in the plan is its illustrative capacity-building scenario: Medford is currently planting about **200 public trees per year**, with an estimated total forestry budget of about **\$790,000**; the example 2030 scenario increases annual planting to about **400 trees** and total forestry budget to about **\$1.2 million**. That scenario also adds **1 forester and 2 laborers**. (pp. 69–70)

About this document

This document covers two categories of Council action:

- Budget and operational asks — what the Forestry Division and administration need appropriated or approved to implement the plan.
- Legislative actions — ordinance amendments and new policies the plan recommends that require City Council votes. The Council passed a Tree Committee ordinance (November 2025) and the Green Score zoning provision (2025) which are noted below as already enacted.

Part I — Legislative Actions (Require City Council Vote)

The plan's PROTECT pillar contains its most direct City Council asks. Several items require ordinance action rather than appropriation. Two have already been enacted; several remain outstanding.

Already Enacted

1. Tree Committee Ordinance (enacted November 2025)

The UFMP recommended that the City **"formally establish a Tree Committee or advisory board by ordinance"** to support policy review, urban forestry planning, and public engagement. (p. 75) The City Council enacted Division 17 of the City Code establishing the Medford Tree Committee (MTC) in November 2025.

Key features of the enacted ordinance:

- Nine-member advisory committee; members appointed by the Mayor with City Council approval, serving staggered 1-, 2-, and 3-year terms; preference for members with urban forestry or landscape design experience, including youth members (ages 15–22).
- Serves in an advisory capacity to the Tree Warden on all matters concerning public shade trees and City-owned property.
- Duties include: assisting with public tree hearings; studying and reporting on urban forest management; reviewing and reporting on the Community Forestry Management Plan and administration's implementation progress; reviewing the annual tree-planting/removal/maintenance report; promoting equity in tree planting; reviewing the public tree inventory; and evaluating mitigation costs assessed by the Tree Warden.
- Reports concerns directly to the City Council.

2. Green Score Zoning Provision (enacted 2025)

The UFMP recommended embedding tree protection requirements into zoning, permitting, and development review. (p. 75) The Council enacted the Green Score as an amendment to the zoning ordinance (Sec. 94), prepared by Innes Associates with Community Development Board amendments.

Key features of the enacted provision:

- Applies to new principal buildings and major renovations (where work area exceeds 50% of building area and work value exceeds 50% of assessed value)

that: (a) are located in a FEMA flood hazard area (Zone A, AE, or X), or (b) require site plan review.

- Establishes a weighted scoring system for landscape elements. Trees earn significant scores: large trees (0.9 multiplier), medium/large trees (0.7), small/medium trees (0.5), small trees (0.3). Preservation of existing trees ≥ 6 inches DBH earns a 1.0 multiplier — the highest available.
- Minimum Green Score thresholds by district currently set for Mystic Avenue Corridor zones (minimum 20–25 / ideal 30); additional districts are TBD.
- Bonus credits for use of native/adaptive species (+0.1), rainwater/greywater irrigation (+0.2), landscaping visible from public right-of-way (+0.1), and food cultivation (+0.1).
- Prohibits invasive species in new plantings; requires removal of invasive species from development sites.
- Requires landscape plans stamped by a registered landscape architect as part of site plan review (new Sec. 94-11.7 requirements).
- Includes a waiver provision (Sec. 94-11.7.18) allowing the Site Plan Review Authority to waive Green Score requirements for design flexibility upon a finding of consistency with the provision's purpose.

Remaining Recommended Legislative Actions

3. Strengthen Chapter 86 — Tree Ordinance Amendments

The plan calls on the City to strengthen its existing vegetation policy (Chapter 86) across several dimensions. (p. 75) The plan notes that Medford's existing codes demonstrate a clear policy interest in public trees but that **"key elements [are] missing that would help to strengthen the urban forest."** (p. 67)

The plan recommends considering:

- Developing tree planting, maintenance, and removal standards, including species diversity guidelines, approved planting methods, pruning standards, and permit requirements for tree removal.
- Adding tree protection requirements during development, including tree protection zones, construction limits near roots, and replanting/mitigation requirements.
- Strengthening enforcement and penalties for illegal removal or damage, including fines and restoration requirements.
- Establishing an appeals and variance process to promote transparency and consistency in decision-making.

Note: The Tree Advisory Subcommittee of the Medford Energy & Environment Committee conducted foundational work on regulatory pathways in 2019 that the UFMP explicitly references as a starting point. (p. 67)

4. Private Tree Ordinance

The plan explicitly recommends: **"Support the development of a private tree ordinance."** (p. 75) It notes that Medford currently has **no comprehensive tree preservation ordinance or private property tree protections**, though it acknowledges existing codes provide a platform for future policy development. (p. 61)

The Tree Committee ordinance includes a comment noting that the MTC could play a role in private tree regulation as a decision-making body to reduce administrative burden on the Tree Warden — though the committee was ultimately established as advisory only, with this question deferred pending further development.

5. Developer Incentive Programs

The plan recommends exploring **"incentive programs to protect and preserve trees, such as developer credits or tax benefits."** (p. 75) Depending on the mechanism, this could require Council action. The Green Score already functions as a partial incentive by allowing a 5-point reduction in the required score for projects that provide additional affordable housing.

6. Embed Tree Protection in Zoning and Permitting

Beyond the Green Score, the plan recommends **"strengthening policy integration by embedding tree protection requirements into zoning, permitting, and development review processes."** (p. 75) This is broader than the Green Score — it includes requiring tree protection and tree replacement as standard conditions of development review across project types. Zoning amendments require Council action.

7. Establish a Tree Fund

The plan lists a Tree Fund as a recommended funding mechanism: **"a fund to accept payments/donations for the purpose of assisting with new programs and staffing, public education, maintenance of existing trees, and planting of new trees."** (p. 82) Formally establishing such a fund would typically require a Council vote. The fund could also serve as the repository for development mitigation fees if a mitigation fee structure is adopted.

8. Development Mitigation Fees / Canopy Replacement Requirements

The plan lists "**Development Mitigation — e.g. mitigation fees, on-site planting requirements, canopy replacement**" as a distinct funding source for urban forestry. (p. 82) Establishing mitigation fees or canopy replacement requirements tied to development approvals would require Council action, likely through both a zoning amendment and a fee ordinance.

Part II — Budget and Operational Asks

I. Staffing

9. Add Forestry Field Staff to "Right Size" the Division

The plan directly recommends that the City "**right size the Forestry Division staff**" so it can shift from primarily reactive work to proactive maintenance. A **three-person field team** is the industry standard, and Medford's current staffing is limited relative to demand. (pp. 69, 76)

What the plan supports:

- Increase from 2 foresters to 3 foresters
- Increase from 1 laborer to 3 laborers (net addition of 2)
- Maintain existing Tree Warden and Foreman positions

(pp. 69–70)

Item	Estimated Annual Cost
1 additional forester	\$90,000–\$130,000 / yr
2 additional laborers (total)	\$140,000–\$220,000 / yr
Total added staffing	\$230,000–\$350,000 / yr

This is the staffing expansion most directly grounded in the plan's own illustrative scenario. (p. 70)

II. Tree Planting and Canopy Expansion

10. Increase the Annual Municipal Planting Contract

The plan recommends increasing the annual municipal planting contract from **200 trees to 400 trees by 2030**. It identifies **984 vacant planting sites** in the public tree inventory. Priority planting should target Environmental Justice population areas. (pp. 45, 74, 79–81)

Item	Estimated Annual Cost
Est. cost per tree (~\$900 in 2030 scenario)	\$900 / tree
Total annual planting cost at 400 trees/yr	~\$360,000 / yr
Incremental cost over current 200-tree level	\$180,000–\$200,000 / yr

(pp. 69–70, 74)

11. Fund Establishment Care for Newly Planted Trees

The plan repeatedly emphasizes proactive care, including **watering during establishment** and a **young tree structural pruning program every 3 years**. Bare-root planting — a potential cost-reduction strategy — would require attention to watering logistics, staffing, and contractor needs before any pilot. (pp. 76–77, 82)

Item	Estimated Annual Cost
Young-tree watering and establishment care	\$40,000–\$100,000 / yr
3-year structural pruning cycle for new trees	\$25,000–\$75,000 / yr
Total young-tree care	\$65,000–\$175,000 / yr

III. Proactive Maintenance and Public Tree Care

12. Build a Proactive Pruning and Maintenance Program

Medford's forestry operation is currently reactive because of both budget and staffing constraints. The plan recommends shifting toward proactive maintenance through routine pruning cycles, young-tree care, and early intervention for pests and diseases, using Management Zones to prioritize resources. (pp. 71, 76–77)

Item	Estimated Annual Cost
Expanded contractor or in-house pruning/maintenance	\$100,000–\$250,000 / yr

This is the likely operating-cost category that accompanies staffing additions above.

IV. Technology, Data, and Management Systems

13. Maintain and Use Tree Inventory Data in Cartegraph

The plan recommends updating tree inventory data in **Cartegraph** during the routine maintenance cycle to track inventory, maintenance needs, and planting performance. (p. 76)

Item	Estimated Annual Cost
Software licensing / configuration / support	\$10,000–\$30,000 / yr
Field tablets / hardware (one-time or periodic)	\$5,000–\$15,000

14. Update Canopy Change Assessment Every 3–5 Years

The plan recommends updating the canopy change assessment every **3–5 years** and notes that Medford may want to pursue funding for more frequent or higher-resolution canopy data. The current baseline uses LiDAR data. (pp. 19, 76)

Item	Estimated Periodic Cost
Canopy / LiDAR / consultant update	\$25,000–\$75,000 per update

15. Update the UFMP Every 5 Years

The plan recommends updating the UFMP every **5 years** to measure success, address challenges, and set new goals. (pp. 76, 82)

Item	Estimated Periodic Cost
Plan update / consultant support / engagement	\$30,000–\$100,000 per update

V. Capital Planning and Project Integration

16. Add Urban Forestry Scope to the Capital Improvement Plan

The plan recommends coordinating tree planting with CIP projects including road reconstruction, park upgrades, and utility work, and lists the CIP as a primary funding source for urban forestry. (pp. 66, 82)

Tree-related costs to embed in capital projects:

- Street-tree planting
- Tree replacement
- Site preparation
- Tree protection/restoration associated with project work

Item	Estimated Annual Cost
Capital set-aside or embedded project cost (to start)	\$100,000–\$300,000 / yr

This is best framed as a direction to departments that future capital projects should budget for trees upfront, rather than as a standalone Forestry Division line item.

VI. Community Partnerships and Funding Support

17. Support Community Planting and Watering Partnerships

The plan recommends continued partnership with **TreesMedford**, nonprofits, schools, and neighborhood groups for planting, stewardship, and engagement. (pp. 67, 74, 82)

Item	Estimated Annual Cost
Small grants / outreach / volunteer / community planting	\$15,000–\$50,000 / yr

Modest line item relative to leverage: volunteer capacity can significantly extend the City's planting and watering reach.

Summary

A. Legislative Actions — Status

Action	Status	Plan Citation
Tree Committee by Ordinance (MTC)	✓ Enacted Nov. 2025	p. 75
Green Score Zoning Provision	✓ Enacted 2025	p. 75
Strengthen Chapter 86 (tree ordinance amendments)	Recommended	p. 75
Private Tree Ordinance	Recommended	pp. 61, 75
Developer Incentive Programs (credits / tax benefits)	Recommended	p. 75
Embed tree protection in zoning / permitting (beyond Green Score)	Recommended	p. 75
Establish a Tree Fund	Recommended	p. 82
Development Mitigation Fees / Canopy Replacement	Recommended	p. 82

B. Budget Summary — Operating and Capital

Item	Estimated Cost
Operating — Items Most Directly Supported by the Plan	
Additional forestry staff (§9)	\$230,000–\$350,000 / yr
Expand planting from 200 to 400 trees/yr (§10)	+\$180,000–\$200,000 / yr incremental
Young-tree watering and structural pruning (§11)	\$65,000–\$175,000 / yr
Proactive pruning / maintenance expansion (§12)	\$100,000–\$250,000 / yr
Technology and Planning Support	
Cartograph / asset-management support (§13)	\$10,000–\$30,000 / yr + hardware
Canopy data update every 3–5 years (§14)	\$25,000–\$75,000 per update
UFMP update every 5 years (§15)	\$30,000–\$100,000 per update

Item	Estimated Cost
Capital and Partnership Support	
Tree-related costs embedded in CIP projects (§16)	\$100,000–\$300,000 / yr to start
Community partnership / Tree Fund / outreach (§17)	\$15,000–\$50,000 / yr

Source: Medford Urban Forest Management Plan, February 2026 (Weston & Sampson); Tree Committee Ordinance, November 2025; Green Score Zoning Provision, CDB Recommendations March 2025. Page citations refer to the UFMP unless otherwise noted.